



▶ AT FULL TILT

Smriti Mandhana etched her name deeper into the record books with a blistering 50-ball century against Australia in the third ODI in New Delhi. The southpaw's hundred was the fastest by an Indian, surpassing Virat Kohli's 52-ball effort, and second only to Meg Lanning's 45-ball ton in women's ODI history. Remarkably, the three fastest ODI centuries by an Indian woman now all belong to Mandhana, who also owns 70-ball and 77-ball hundreds. Her 125 off 63 balls came on a run-fest in the capital, with India responding to Australia's imposing 412 with a spirited 369, aided by fifties from Harmanpreet Kaur and Deepti Sharma. The match set a new record for the highest aggregate in a Women's ODI, with 781 runs and a staggering 111 boundaries. Mandhana struck 17 fours and five sixes and recorded the second-highest strike rate for a women's ODI hundred. Her series scores of 58, 117 and 125 fetched her 343 runs, the most ever in a three-match women's ODI series.

▶ KEEPER OF COURAGE

Hannah Hampton was on the bench when England lifted its first major trophy at the Women's European Championship on home soil in 2022. In the months that followed, she found herself frozen out of the squad, amid allegations of disruptive behaviour, claims that were later attributed to comments made by senior goalkeeper Mary Earps.

The fallout lingered. England's build-up to its title defence in Switzerland was overshadowed by Sarina Wiegman's bold decision to elevate Hampton to first choice ahead of Earps. The move prompted Earps to announce her international retirement on the eve of the tournament, leaving England with Hampton as the only capped goalkeeper in the squad and placing unprecedented responsibility on her shoulders.

Hampton responded in the only currency that truly settles elite sport. In the final, she delivered one of the most decisive penalty shootout performances in tournament history, saving spot-kicks from Mariona Caldentey and Aitana Bonmatí to swing the title England's way.

Wiegman described it as a fairytale moment, but it was also a triumph of resolve. "She had to step up, and I think she has been amazing," the England coach said. "To stop those two penalties in the final is extraordinary."

Hampton later revealed another detail that endeared her to supporters. She had deliberately thrown Spanish goalkeeper Cata Coll's water bottle, containing notes on England's penalty takers, into the stands before the shootout.

Once labelled disruptive, Hampton had instead been decisive. In this case, instinct, nerve, and a willingness to own the moment carried England to back-to-back European titles.

